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Fred Radke

Fred Radke is a trumpeter, big band conductor, and music educator. He was thrilled to become a member of the Harry James trumpet section, and was recognized for his devotion to the band by being appointed a director in 1989. Fred has also lent his talents to numerous projects for the United States Navy.

Fred was interviewed in Hillsdale, Michigan on November 8, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

[begins at 10:13]

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm here at beautiful Hillsdale College with Fred Radke, and I'm very pleased to meet you. And you've already enthralled me with some stories so you're just going to have to tell them all again.

FR: Oh, I don't know about that.

MR: I wanted to ask you, when in your youth did you decide that you wanted to be a professional musician?

FR: Well I wanted to be a trumpet player, that was the first thing I wanted to be. Period.

MR: Trumpet comes before?

FR: Anything. Yeah. I was, I don't know, about six or — about seven — and I saw Harry James on television. And I said, "That's what I want to play, and that's what I want to do." So grammar school — you were supposed to be a year older to get a horn but we talked to the teacher and I got a horn from the school, some beat-up old Buescher cornet you know. And I wanted to play. And I started playing and playing in the school band. And then in Oakland, I grew up in Oakland, California, that's my hometown. And there was a famous youth band there called The Welldonians. And it was a 250 piece marching band. And it was very dedicated young musicians from the age of two to eighteen. And outstanding, the older trumpet players were really good you know, that later on became known players. But it was a very militaristic organization, very disciplined. Finally when you learned your parade routine and let's say you played third trumpet, you had to audition in front of three officers in order to get your parade uniform, your cape and cap. And you had to do the 15-minute routine, marching steps, and you're playing third — with nothing else around you — and you were allowed to make zero mistakes. You made one mistake you didn't get the thing, and come back in two weeks.

MR: Would that include the marching part of it?

FR: Oh absolutely. This was an incredible — when this unit marched down the street — now all these big bands, school bands, are something. But this was one of the first ones like that. It was an experience to see. Precision perfect. You rehearsed, I mean you were dedicated like three or four days a week. Saturday you rehearsed all day from nine in the

morning 'til nine at night, marching, doing routines, learning marches. I went from 67th chair to first chair, and later on became the assistant conductor of the band when I was about 14. And so then I left the band and of course I'm listening to Harry James all the time. I mean he's my mentor. It's all — that's — focused on Harry. And so my teacher says, "You know if you're going to play you should join the union." So I joined the union when I was 15 and yes I auditioned. I had to play all my major scales and play "Stardust."

MR: Do you think they would have denied you membership if you couldn't play that well? Because I've heard a couple of stories from other musicians —

FR: Well it all depends where you were. This is San Francisco Local 6. So I don't know. I mean later on I think everybody had to audition in those times, and it was I think $50 to join the union and $9 a quarter or something you know. So my teacher was the top trumpet player in San Francisco. Dick Lawter and a first call guy. And so see that's the smart thing to do. If you move to a city, I've told students this, if you want to go to New York or something, or wherever, find out who the number one call player is, and you call him up and say, "Hi this is Fred Radke, I'm a trumpet player and I'm moving to New York because I want to study with you and no one else." And naturally the guy will say, "Well I don't teach anymore" or "I'm busy." And you say, "Okay, well this is the reason I'm coming to the City, I want to meet you and I want to study with you." So you let that rest for a few days, you call him back again, finally the guy says, "All right, why don't you come by." Boom — there you go. So Dick Lawter gave me a list of all the trumpet players in San Francisco, which there are really good trumpet players. And he says, "You call these guys every week." So I remember — I had the union book and I listed out like ten or fifteen trumpet players. And you would get a call every Wednesday afternoon from Fred Radke. Well after you figure out it said, "Who in the heck is Fred Radke? Well he keeps calling me." And this is strange — Saturday a lot of times you would get a call to make a gig Saturday night, like 4:00 — somebody would get sick, there was a contractor saying well I need a trumpet player. So one night I get a call at 5:30. They said, "This is Fred Radke? This is Jack Fisher" who was a big contractor in San Francisco. I've got a show and a dance tonight at the Fairmont Hotel, my trumpet player came down with the flu, I need somebody, you come highly recommended from Dick Lawter, so the talk-over is at 7:00, the show is at 8:30, we play from 10 to 1:00 — tuxedo and be there." And I said, "Okay, what is the show?" All of a sudden for some reason I guess my voice, something says, "How old are you?" I said, "I just turned 16." "Have you ever played a show?" I said, "No." And he said, "Well then I can't use you, I'm sorry, good luck to you." And I said, "Wait a minute, I have a question for you." I said, "How do you have an opportunity or experience to play a show if no one ever hires you because you haven't played a show, so therefore how do you do that? So I'm asking you, let me play the show

so I get the experience to say that I've played a show so I can get other jobs to play shows and dances." And it's silence. And Jack Fisher says, "Be there at 7:00." So now I show up there, right? And I get there early and we're in the room and there's like twelve musicians and typical talk-over. "Okay we've got a dog act, a singer, juggler" whatever the heck it was. And they said, "Okay the first thing is now we vamp at Letter A, we vamp 'til the act enters the thing and then when they throw the ball up in the air we play this chord and then we — da-da-da — and everybody's got their pencil out. I'm standing there and I had the first trumpet book because the other trumpet player isn't there. And I said, "Who's playing lead?" And they said so and so — Merv Gruthers or somebody. And he says, "Well where is he?" And he says, "I don't know where he is, you take the book." So I'm watching everybody, how they're marking — and watching the little thing, used to put glasses

MR: I remember that.

FR: Remember drawing glasses?

MR: Sure.

FR: Remember drawing glasses to say "Look out here!" And so I'm watching these guys. So now it gets like 15 minutes before the show and in walks the trumpet player. "God I'm sorry, I was caught in traffic." And Fisher says, "I don't care, that's not an excuse. As you know professional musicians, you're dead if you're late. Never be tardy, ever. And so he says, "Well I'm sorry, where's my music?" And he says, "Here." He said, "Well this is the second trumpet book." And he said, "That's right, that's what you're playing. Fred's playing lead." "Who the hell are you?" I said, "I'm Fred Radke." And he says, "Yeah? What do you do?" I said, "Well obviously I'm going to play the trumpet." And he says, "You're playing lead and I'm playing second? Well you better be real good." So like Bobby Shew said in that interview, "Do you know this guy Bobby Shew?" "Yeah." "He plays all the high notes, man he never misses. Have you heard his jazz playing?" "Oh yeah, he's great, he's something else." But he says, "Go out to a gig and miss one F then they say, "You know this guy Bobby Shew, you know he missed an F?" And they said, "Oh yeah, I know." Well it's the same thing. That was the proving ground that night for me.

MR: How did it go?

FR: Perfect. I played — really, playing a dog act and playing some chords. You know play "Saints Go Marching In" or something.

MR: That's a whole part of musicianship that you have to learn on the job. I remember playing for Connie Francis once and they had the music on this one particular page with black marker was all covered up. In red marker it said, "Play all of this." So you're going what's the right thing to do here, and you just have to like pay attention.

FR: Well I'll give you an experience like that. When I joined Harry James we were in Vegas with Phil Harris. And so we were playing the same thing every night, right? Then we went out on the road and the trumpet player before me was bugged, he got fired, which you know a lot of guys did before, because they did something, I don't know. And this guy took the book and in those days it wasn't a condensed book like I carry now, because it was the whole Harry James library on each side you had that much music, right? You had your own case. And it's like the Glenn Miller band carries, those guys carry all their music. I asked the guys, I said, "Do you guys play all of this?" "Oh yeah." Well okay. Well Harry didn't play certain things but they were in the book. This guy shuffled the book. Now you don't think that isn't kind of rotten. And when Harry James would call up a tune it would be — finally I memorized really. You'd be playing and he'd go [scats] you had to read his lips. He didn't tell you the number — 1735 — if you didn't know the number you'd better start looking. And then you talk about marks, the guy sitting next to you is jealous because he didn't get the first trumpet chair 'cause he's been there for two years and he thinks he should be there, but once you were a third trumpet player you were always a third trumpet player and that's where you were going to stay. So now here's a new guy comes in from the Northwest with a tilted bell trumpet, who in the hell is this guy, and then you say, "It says start at Letter A, no start at Letter D, no cut to Letter C, no take the coda the first time." Which do you do here? I don't know.

MR: Was there a difference in the salary between —

FR: Oh yes.

MR: The lead trumpet guy is getting more bread?

FR: Oh yes. That's why I was the first trumpet player. That's why I am a first trumpet player. And well anyway —

MR: Let me ask you about the relationship between the lead trumpet player and the drummer?

FR: I know, I've heard you ask that question, okay? Extremely important. That's the most important — sorry saxophone players — the lead trumpet player and the drummer are the whole foundation of a band. A lead trumpet player, even in an orchestra or in the President's band, they set the timbre for the band, the first trumpet player. They set the timbre for the orchestra or for the band. It's extremely important that you think alike. I've played with some great drummers and of course when I was with Harry and my dear old friend Sonny Payne, Sonny — we played really good together. And to me Sonny Payne was the best. And there's nobody that played like Sonny Payne. And he would read your mind, he would read Harry's mind. In fact I was just talking to the drummer here — Sonny when he'd be playing he'd be looking at Harry and he was like reading what Harry was going to do. He'd just be staring at him, like this. And if Harry went [motions] Sonny

was right there, just like that. And so the lead trumpet player is laying it down, you've got to be right in sync with the drummer. Absolutely.

MR: I have a quote for you from drummer Gregory Caputo, when he played with the Harry James band.

FR: He's a great guy, Greg.

MR: He said, "Fred having played with Harry James when Sonny Payne was playing the drums expected no less from me. I had to step-up my intensity and kick the band with the forcefulness of a Howitzer cannon.

FR: Yeah. I'm famous for drummers. Well that's what I've been told. When I was a guest soloist — one of the most important jobs I've ever done in my life — a guest soloist for the President's own Marine Band, which was very important to me. And Jason — Colonel Fettig, who just retired by the way — invited me to do the Fiftieth Anniversary of Wolf Trap. And so I go in for the rehearsal in Washington and of course here's the greatest musicians in the world sitting in this band. I said I've never seen so many Sergeant-Majors in my life in one place. And the drummer came up to me and he says, "I've been waiting for you." I said, "What do you mean by that?" And he says, "Oh I've heard about you and drummers." I said, "What have you heard?" And he says, "Well I've just heard some things." And he was a great, just a great player. And he was with Andy Williams for years, he knew how to play.

MR: It seems like a hard thing to define, like does it have a lot to do with the drummer — where he plays his fills and setting up the downbeat? And you two have to be like in sync.

FR: He's got to set — he has to set you up and to get that excitement going, you know the intensity. You know because you know I traveled, well I traveled with Leslie Uggams and I traveled with the King family, they always used to carry — and Jerry McKenzie was a drummer with the Kings, they'd carry a lead trumpet player and a drummer and a conductor/piano. That's the main thing. Period. And you had, that's what most acts carried. That was good — guys like would travel with Robert Goulet as his first trumpet player and so on — those were really well paying jobs. My old friend that I knew was Elvis's lead trumpet player man. He took care of those guys and the drummer — I mean that was the main catalyst of traveling, and then you picked up the rest of the orchestra. But you made a very good salary being a first trumpet player for people. Like Tommy Porrello was with Vic you know. I mean they'd go to Florida or something, he always brought Tommy, he always took Joey Preston, his drummer who was just like Sonny, and his pianist/conductor. And that's what you brought. Those were good jobs to obtain you know.

MR: Did you have it in the back of your mind that someday you might direct the Harry James Orchestra?

FR: Well this is so — I'm playing in the East Bay in a night club, and they were booking acts like Frank Sinatra Jr., Leslie Ugg — I mean Dorothy Dandridge — my phone — and a group called The Lancers, and it was a vocal quartet. They had done a lot of T.V. They were with Kay Starr. Made some hit records. And they were headlining at Harrah's in Tahoe, in Nevada. They were the headlining act. And in those days Bill Harrah — the lounges were very important. And they would have junkets for gamblers to go up from the Bay Area — you'd go up and get there at 8:00, you'd gamble all night, get up and leave at 8:00 in the morning to get back. And that was a big thing. So lounges, you went to work at 1:00 in the morning and worked until 5 or 6 in the morning. And Harrah's — Bill Harrah, who was a terrific guy, he had The Lancers, he let them headliner — he had Louie Prima, he had Keely Smith, Harry James. So I said, "Ah." The Lancers came through this nightclub and I said — and their trumpet player, which they carried, went to go with Stan Kenton as his lead player. And so they were talking about that and I thought — and I'm 18 at this time — and I said, "Hmm this is my chance to meet Harry James." Because that's all I want — here I'm focused on Harry James. In fact my sister the other day, on my birthday, says, "I never forgot you were about ten years old and we were in the front room with our parents and you walked in, you were practicing, you walked in with your trumpet and said, 'I've decided what I'm going to do. I'm going to be Harry James's first trumpet player'" my sister said, "and you were ten years old when you said that." And I said, "And I'm going to do it." My father says, "Good for you." Right? So now this is my chance to meet Harry. Well dummy, naturally if The Lancers are the headliners at Reno, Harry's not going to be there, he's going to be at Tahoe. So we were never in the same venue. So now time goes on and The Lancers break up, and one guy when to go write for "Lassie" for Tom Scott's dad, Nathan Scott. And so on, and The Lancers kind of fell apart. So I said well you know at this time I'm like 21. I'd go to Vegas and I'd put in my union card. And I really don't know anybody in Vegas you know at that time. So one morning I was subbing on the "Steve Allen Show" or something. And I'd go out to the bar and it's 3:00 in the morning and I'm going to get a corned beef sandwich and a beer. And this guy next to me has three hookers hanging on him drinking, slopping martinis up, and the guy next to me is having French toast with strawberries and whipped cream and I'm having a beer and a sandwich. And I look out in the casino and all this stuff going on. And I said, "God this stinks. This really is a lousy way to live." And I thought I've got to get out of here. I can't stand this. So I go over and pick up the phone and call this manager of a lady in Seattle that ran the Edmonds Yacht Club. And we had just played there with The Lancers. And she says, "If you ever come to

Seattle you call me, I'll hire you." Because he had a band that worked five nights a week. So I had her phone number and called her up, and she says, "I'm serious," she said, "it's funny you should call, Fred, I'm looking for a band to start next week. How would you like a year contract?" I said, "Really? Okay you got it." I said, "I'll be there." So I called the best musicians in Seattle, which are really good player, a rhythm section. I get in my car and I'm thinking Jesus, I need a place to stay, I didn't think about this. So now I have another friend of mind that lived on Bainbridge Island and he had this beach house that was right on the beach in Manitou Beach. And you walk out and in those days Bainbridge Island — it was a summer place. Not many people wintered there. And there's Seattle, you're right on Puget Sound. And there's the whole city landscape. So I called this guy up and said, "You know I'm thinking of coming to Seattle, I've got a gig at the Edmonds Yacht Club for a year and we're going to do it." And he says, "It's funny you should call" he says, "we're going to the desert for six months. Why don't you come and stay at the house?" And I said, "Well I can't afford" and he says, "No I just want somebody to stay here." "Okay." So now I have a pad and a gig. So here I go. I go to Seattle and start working, and naturally The Lancers were pretty well known. So when I showed up into town to do any extra shows, everybody kind of moved down a chair. You know I said, don't get me wrong I mean — but they said, "Fred Radke's in town," everybody — when you went out on a gig the guy that used to play lead now moved down. Nothing was said. And so we played the Olympic Hotel, which they had a big showroom, and they had a singer there that had just come from the Johnny Carson show and she was the longest running act at the Hungry Eye in San Francisco and she was very well known. She was opera-trained but she was a nightclub singer and a very elegant lady, just an incredible singer. And so her piano player decides to go to Nashville to join somebody and so she says well who am I going to get for my conductor. And he says, "Well you remember Fred Radke that played opposite —" She said, "I don't want a trumpet player, are you kidding? So that's my wife Gina Funes. We've been married going on 58 years, okay. And so we were starting to work shows together after I left the yacht club. And so we were going to work a convention and Joe Venuti lived in Seattle, the world's greatest violinist.

MR: So he says.

FR: And so we did these shows together. And so we're driving to Spokane and he's in the back seat and he says, "You know you guys are perfect for each other. You should get married." And we said, "Well we've been talking about it." "Oh you've got to get married. Why don't we go elope." So we didn't stop at Spokane, we went to Cour d'Alene and we eloped. Now it gets even funnier. We get the license, go to the Justice of the Peace, and of course the Justice of the Peace is about 350 years old you know, and he

says, “Well I’m very sorry, my wife usually plays piano but she can’t play piano because she’s ill with the flu.” And I said, “Well you know who this is?” So during the ceremony I stood at the — I guess the altar — and Joe Venuti played piano — he was a very good pianist, and Gina sang at my own wedding. Okay so now we go back to work this big show and there’s about a thousand people and Joe Venuti says, “Tonight you know I get to introduce Gina Funes and Fred Radke. They just got married today” [mumbles]. And everybody applauds. So Gina comes out and does her thing and she’s sensational you know. And I mean really elegant, really something. And so she said, “Tonight is the first night I’m going to get to introduce my conductor to you as my husband, Mr. Fred — Mr. Fred — ” and she couldn’t think of my last name. Well Venuti on the side, Venuti said, “Radke.” So that turns out. So now time goes on, Gina and I go to Southeast Asia during the war and we do two tours over there for private agents. It was just terrible in those days, Thailand and the Philippines. And so I came back and Venuti is in town playing and with Corky Corcoran, who is a famous saxophone player. So I said why don’t we go down — I’ve never met Corky. I mean we know each other, let’s go see Venuti. We haven’t seen him for six months. So we go down and see him and, hey, “Love to see you guys” he says — I said, “What are you doing Joe?” He says, “I’m opening next week with Harry James and Phil Harris in Vegas. Have you ever played with Harry?” And Gina says, “You have to ask him that? That’s all he’s ever wanted to do.” And Joe says, “You don’t — Harry James doesn’t know you?” And I said, “No.” “And you never played with?” I said, “Joe, I told you.” “Oh.” Two days later, “This is Pee Wee Monte from Harry James, we’d like you to join the band, the first trumpet chair is open and when are you available?” I said, “Well I have some commitments.” “We know that. When will you be available?” And then they said, I’ve never been asked this, and they said, “What do you need?” What do I need? I’m thinking. “Well let me tell you what we’re going to pay, we’re offering to pay you, and then we can negotiate it.” Well they came right with a high, good figure and not like what Sonny was making but I — and then when you went to Vegas you worked seven days so your salary was really up there because you got time and time and a half. So here I am now, my dream come true.

MR: And you were how old?

FR: 23. And I go down — or 22. I go down and I’m there and Harry comes in. And the manager introduces me to Harry. And Harry says, “Yes I know who you are, Fred, you were with The Lancers” because word got around you know. And in the back as I’m standing there shaking Harry James’s hand, Venuti comes in from the back of the showroom and he says, “Hey Harry.” And of course Harry says, “Joe, how are you?” And he says, “It’s about time you hired a trumpet player that plays as good as you.” I thought, timing. So now I go with Harry and I’m tickled to death. And of course Corky

Corcoran and I have become very close, roommates, and then when Corky's wife was with them I roomed with Sonny. So Sonny and I were really close. And so it was like Red Carey, Perciful, the great pianist that was with him for years, Sonny, Corky, myself, and it was kind of, I was in that kind of a different clique than the younger guys.

MR: Were some of the chairs the second tenor and third trombone etcetera filled by local guys that when the band moved on maybe they didn't go with the band?

FR: No. No. See in those days everybody went to high schools, went to a hot shot college, went to a jazz camp, got their degree finally from college, then they got on a band, and they got on a band to get to Vegas, when they got on Vegas then they'd jump off in Vegas. And then you'd stay in Vegas. If you were really good in Vegas, like Tommy and those guys, then you were invited to L.A. That was the plan.

MR: That was the path.

FR: That was the path. And Harry used to get bugged because guys would get on the band and then would jump band in Vegas. But I didn't want to do that you know. And I just — and Harry, I think that he went through something like 14 first trumpet players in like two months before I got there. In fact Bobby Shew was in Vegas and he came to pick me up and we knew each other, you know, from the NORAD days. I remember him picking me up. He probably doesn't even remember this but he says, "You know everybody's talking about you, you're the only guy that's been with Harry for more than two months in that chair."

MR: How did he deal with the ever-changing musical tastes?

FR: We did, you know we were doing some Blood, Sweat & Tears things. He always had a good singer too, on the band, a female singer. Really good, except once. That sounds pretty funny. But no, he always had a dynamite singer and he tried to do some modern things. We did like "Traces" and he did "Spinning Wheel" and he did things like that. We spent a lot of time in Vegas because that's where his home was. And we'd go out — I never really went — he never went out like we did with the Fiftieth Anniversary. We did four months of one-nighters off a bus, you were talking about that. And that's brutal but it is what it is. And most of the guys who were on the band would stay on the band. And some guys would jump. But when I left the band it was the most difficult thing I think that — one of the most difficult things that I had to do, because it was a job that I loved. I could hardly wait to get on the bandstand, I was so thrilled. And he knew that. He could tell. And then I knew Harry, we had social friends. I knew him — we had mutual friends socially. Like he was a real sports guy. If a famous musician walked into the room and a famous baseball player or a sports figure, he would gravitate to the sports figure before he would to the musician. Okay? Well my very dear friend that took my place when I went with the band as Gina's conductor was Bill Muncie. And Bill Muncie was the world's —

still is, gone now — world's greatest unlimited hydroplane driver. I mean he hit — won more gold cups, anything, world records, 67 victories, and Harry was a fan of his. And so he'd come up and he said, "What happened to Bill today in Detroit? What did he say?" And then Bill came by to see me a few times with the band. And so see it was on a different level. And then he loved Corky. Corky was his adopted son you know that don't you?

MR: I did not know that.

FR: And well I'll get to that in a second. But so I'm sitting on the band. The reason I left the band, I had an offer from a friend of mine to start the jazz department at North Seattle Community College, a brand new college. And I'm sitting there. And when I joined Harry I thought, you know everybody says wow isn't it great to be on there. You know I said I'm going to analyze him. I want to be — I want to know what makes him tick. What makes him not only a very famous band and very charismatic and he and Betty Grable were the highest paid movie stars in Hollywood in the early '40s. And what made him be the greatest trumpet player? What makes him tick? So that's how I approached it. And so one night I'm sitting on the band and I went through everybody in the band you know. And everybody was divorced or separated except one guy. And so I had this offer of this job, I said you know I've done it, I love this job. So I called Gina after every show. And I said, we had a new son, two years old. Harry helped me buy my house on Mercer Island, and I called Gina up and I said, "I think I'm going to leave the band."

MR: I bet she was shocked.

FR: Silence. And she says, "Why would you want to leave the job that you've always wanted that you love, and you're doing exactly what you want to do? Why would you do that? And I said, "I just think it's time for me to come home." And she says, "Well that's going to be your decision, okay? But let me tell you something, don't you ever mention to me that I made you leave Harry James. That's your decision and that's your decision alone." So I went and knocked on Harry's door and I said, "Harry, I think it's time I go home." That's just what I told him. And he looked at me and he says, "Fred, you're one of the smart ones" he says, "you're the type of guy that doesn't want to end up out here like these guys." I said, "Well I've been offered this" and I said, "you know I'm going to start a band at home and do some things." And he says, "Okay." He called Pee Wee and he says, "Now Fred's leaving the band." I said, "I'm giving you six weeks." He says, "Thank you." And he says, "I'll make you a deal. You can come back to this band any time you want. I expect you to come back not just for a week but to come back." And he says, "You don't call the office, here's my personal phone number and you call me." Okay? Which is pretty nice. Then he told Pee Wee, he says, "Anything that Fred needs, any arrangements, tell him he can have whatever he wants" he said, "just do me a favor

and don't give them to anybody else. But you can have whatever I've got." Now that's a pretty — which they sent me stuff that I still have today and now I have the whole library. But so that was pretty interesting. And then I went back to the band three or four times. And you know like Corky would be playing and he'd be having a problem with the trumpet section, Harry'd go, "Why don't you get a hold of Fred and see if he can come out and help us out for three or four days" you know. And then when Harry ever came to the area where you were you always went to visit him. You never didn't go see him. And one time I was gone with Gina on the road, and some guys went by to see them, Red Kelly was off the band at that time. And the first thing Red says, Harry says, "Where's Fred? Is he coming by?" You went by to pay your respects to him. That was important to him. So my thing is when I get ready to go on stage and they're introducing the band and I'm standing and getting ready to enter I think boy, a complete circle. I take it very seriously. And I think, to have the opportunity and to be able to, you know, be in the position that a guy like he occupied is very, very important and I'm very serious about it. And that's what I try to live up to those standards.

MR: Remember George Simon the writer?

FR: Of course.

MR: He wrote this about Harry. He says, "With a vibrato that could easily span the distance from left field to first base —

FR: Okay. You want to know about that?

MR: Yeah.

FR: Conte Candoli summed it up. Now the book that was written on Harry, *Trumpet Blues* I was interviewed by the author, God, for a week. When that book came out he called me and apologized. He says, "Fred, you're the first individual I interviewed about Harry James that looked at him on a different level you know, like, instead of just funny stories and this stuff happened." And that book is good at the beginning but there's other things in the book, it was like how, it was the negative part of Harry James instead of the positive parts of what he contributed to jazz trumpet playing, which he was one of the greatest jazz — Nat Pierce says, "Harry James is one of the greatest jazz trumpet players that ever lived, man." What do you think he did with Benny Goodman? What was that? Was that corned beef hash or something? I don't think so. He was a hell of a lead trumpet player and jazz player, did them both. So Conte Candoli, he was asked about the vibrato thing. And you know what Harry told him one time? He supposedly, he says, "I play a ballad because I hear my mother, that's the way she would sing it to me." What can you say? Okay? So there is nobody, my thing, I love ballads because I think that that really, you invite people in to see who you really are when you play a ballad. And Harry played ballads like nobody. Sorry. Him and Clifford.

MR: This was the vibrato he did with his hand?

FR: Guys do it with their lip or with their hand. You can do either one.

MR: Okay.

FR: I can — you know like you know a lot of people say, "God, you play that just like Harry." I say no you don't. You don't play it like Harry." Tony Scodwell was one of the great trumpet players, a Vegas guy that makes my horns, he's an incredible guy. He was with Harry. And Tony told me, he says, "Nobody plays like Harry but you know what you do Fred? You have the spirit of Harry James. You have that spirit." Nobody plays like Harry James man. Technically, anything. I don't care who you are.

MR: When you get a concert to do and you have to plug in a few players, is there something you say to them to get them in the spirit of the Harry James sound?

FR: Well they know what I expect. You know I've been doing this since 1989, I mean running the band. And you know, you get your guys throughout the country, they know what you expect, they know what your standards are. If you're a young guy then it's really important to sit down and listen to the music to feel out what era you're playing. And there's some tough things on this book. I don't think it's tough, but I've been told by guys that "Jeez, Fred, it's not an easy book, man." I said, "What do you mean?" "It's not easy." But no, I don't have that problem. I don't have that problem. When I walk on stage and even my college kids I used to say, "Okay gentlemen, saddle up, lock and load and take no prisoners. You know let's go out and do it, man." And that's just my attitude.

MR: What kinds of things might happen with an individual where you would either have to let them go or not call them again?

FR: Do you know who Everett Longstreth is?

MR: Say it again?

FR: Do you know who Everett Longstreth is?

MR: No.

FR: A great arranger, great trumpet player with Woody Herman, Berklee School of Music, New England, MIT. Greg Caputo's good friend, that's where I met Greg. Contractor. Great trumpet player. And Everett — I owe Everett a lot. He's re-done a lot of the arrangements and things. And he says, "You never yell at a guy, you just don't call them anymore." You know so and if you walked on my bandstand and you're 15 minutes late, "Oh man I'm really sorry I'm late man, you won't believe what — " I don't want to hear. If you're late, you have an excuse, I don't care what your excuse is, just don't be late again. If you're drunk on the bandstand, okay, that's cool, once. But don't do it again. Don't embarrass me. And even when we were out on the road with a younger band on that Fiftieth Anniversary tour of Harry James, the band — Harry never let the band get

loose. It wasn't like, hey man, you know. As soon as it started getting a little too relaxed he'd pull it together.

MR: How so?

FR: His attitude. You know a trumpet player one night, a new trumpet player, and he missed an E on the end of "Shiny Stockings" [scats] and he cracked it, right? Because there's no mistakes, no mistakes. Harry walked right back to the trumpet section. He says, "You know guys we play a physical instrument. I mean you know it's a physical instrument, you know? And you know you're allowed to make a mistake on my band once." And he turned around and walked off.

MR: "You've been warned."

FR: See? See that's it. Another thing that Harry James did, and I learned this from him too, he signed your paycheck. And sometimes, most times, he would hand you your paycheck. And I noticed this too when we were doing this a lot, when a guy says, "Thank you for the job" or just grabs it. Harry James would hire an individual that had a great attitude and maybe not the player that this guy is, but this guy has a lousy attitude, but this guy's got a positive attitude. He'd keep the job. That's what he wanted. And Harry would go through a stage, you wouldn't know when to approach him and when not to approach him. Sometimes when he wasn't feeling good, you know he had — one time we were on the road in Florida, his malaria flared up. He got malaria when he wintered in Texas with a circus band with his father's band in Beaumont. I think that's where he acquired it. And that's why he never went in the service, he had those things. And one time he was really ill and he showed up at the gig and he didn't — he hadn't been drinking at all. And I caught that and Corky — I said, "Uh oh, now this is the serious Harry James." And I don't know these guys man, these two young trumpet players were standing there, the timing was awful, I never forgot this. These two guys says, "Man, you know something, we're playing the same thing, 'You Made Me Love You' — " Well Harry played all of his hit records, that's what the people wanted him to do, and then we played what we wanted to do. See that's the first thing you do. You play — Joe Graydon from Columbia Artists told me this. You have the Harry James Orchestra, you go out and you play every blockbuster. Bap bap bap. The people want to hear it. Then you can do what you want to do, do all the Thad Jones, Ernie Wilkins charts man, Neal Hefti charts, do whatever you want. But you've proven your point. What you've done with the audience is say you invited me in and now you're confident that I'm in your front room now and now you've accepted me. Now I can do what the heck I want man. Okay? So here's these guys there, saying "Why do we — " And Harry's standing there oiling his valves and he says, "Hi guys." And I'm standing there with Corky and Corky says, "Look out." So now we're playing this thing and there's ten thousand people in this arena or something, for a law

enforcement — a national law enforcement association or something. And they said, "And now, Harry James" and he walks out and people applaud. Harry comes up and he says — and he always started with the theme, like we do, "Ciribiribin" and then "Don't Be That Way" because that's what Benny opened Carnegie Hall with. We still do that. That's tradition. And it fits. And he walked on the stage and he says, "Jazz Connoisseur." Well that's one of his favorite Ernie Wilkins charts, right? I hadn't played it yet. I'd been on the band a year. And I look at Sonny, I said, "'Jazz Connoisseur'? What number is that?" And he says, "I don't know man." Okay. And then he looked at me and he says, "Fred are you playing lead on this?" And I said, "Yeah." And he says, Pass it down to the fourth trumpet player." He's one of the guys. He did that for about three songs. And then they were gone the next day. And when Harry used to fire people he'd say — not very often — but he'd walk up to you and say, "Go home."

MR: What?

FR: Not like a "You're fired, get off my bandstand." He'd say, "Go home." And we were on the band bus and Connie Hayes was standing next to me and we were on the Fiftieth Anniversary. And I don't know, somebody said something. I said, "Why don't you go home?" And she says, "I haven't heard that phrase since I was with Harry James in 1939." I said, "What? Go home?" She says, "Oh yeah, that's how he used to fire guys." He'd say, "Go home." Very low key to get the point across.

MR: Sometimes I've felt like I was born too late.

FR: Oh yeah. I was too.

MR: You ever get that feeling?

FR: Absolutely. Oh absolutely. You know who Joe Bushkin was?

MR: Yes.

FR: Well Joe was my good friend and we played together — I did his last album. Joe and I belonged to an organization together that we spent time together. And Bushkin used to — he told me, he says, "Fred, you were born too late." And of course Bushkin, you know who Bushkin's best friend was Bunny Berigan. That was his buddy. He says, "I love Harry James, believe me," he says, "but nobody played like Bunny. He was the best you know. And oh Bushkin was something else. But let me digress for a second about Corky Corcoran. Corky Corcoran was like from Tacoma and he was like 15 years old and he was a master player, and Jimmie Lunceford comes through town and he says, "You know I want to play with this band." The piano player says, "Nobody sits in with this band. You know who these guys are?" I think Coleman Hawkins was on the band or something. He said, "Yeah I know who is on the band." He said, "You don't understand, I play as good as these guys." "How old are you?" "15, why?" "Man, good luck." And so he says, "Well you know I have a key to the union." Corky told me this story by the way. "I have

a key to the union, I can go down there and anytime and jam anytime I want, why don't you guys come down and jam with me?" So he keeps bugging the piano player. So 2:00 in the morning, whatever, they go down to the union. He says, "Okay, kid, what do you want to play?" "Well play 'Cherokee.'" And that was the tune. Okay. "What key do you want to do it in?" "All of them. We'll start with C and go around the horn." "Really? What tempo?" "Well about [beats rhythm]" So he gets done playing, "Can you play a ballad?" He plays "Body and Soul." He calls up Jimmie Lunceford, 3:00 in the morning. Mr. Lunceford. They always referred to him as "Mr. Lunceford," not Jimmie or boss, but "Mr. Lunceford, this is so-and-so." "Well it's 3:00 in the morning, what are you doing?" He says, "I have something, you've got to come down and hear this young man play." "What are you talking about?" "You've got to come down and hear this kid play." So Lunceford gets dressed, Corky says, and he comes down and he's in his overcoat and he says, "Okay what are you gonna do?" He plays for him and he says, "How old are you?" He said, "I'm 15." "You play like that, how long you been playing?" "I don't know two or three years." "You play like that?" He says, "Yeah." "Okay give me your phone number." So a few months passed, he gets a phone call, "Corky this is Mr. Lunceford, I'm calling from Los Angeles." And Corky says, "Yes." He says, "My friend Sonny Dunham is starting his band and he's looking for young talent and I told him about you and I'd like to send for you to come to Los Angeles to audition for him." And Corky says, "Well you mean I have to stand there and play all alone?" He says, "No, I'm going to feature you with my band at The Palladium." And he says, "Well I'll have to go ask my mother." So they fly Corky's mother and Corky, and here he's at The Palladium playing with Jimmie Lunceford. Sonny Dunham hires him. The talk is all over. Big article in DownBeat, 15-year-old saxophone player. You ask anybody that grew up in that era. They said, "Corky Corcoran, are you kidding me?" Everybody said "Wow look at this." So now he's playing in New York. And Sonny Dunham says, "Harry James is coming in to see you tonight." He says, "Harry James, Whoa." So he says, "Harry walks in there with his entourage and Sonny Dunham calls me up and Corky says, "I played four measures, four measures of a ballad, Harry got up and walked out." He said, "Well I really impressed him." So he goes back to his hotel room at 2:00 in the morning and the phones rings, and he says, "As Harry James' manager we'd like to have you — Mr. James would like to have you join the band." And Corky says, "Well you know I've got another six months to go with Sonny Dunham you know." And he says, "No, we've taken care of that." So he says, "The bus leaves at 9:00 in front of the Roosevelt Hotel be there." Click. So now he's on the band.

MR: That's sort of like a basketball team. Like you've been traded man.

FR: Oh yeah I know. No it's the same thing. Now Corky's telling me this and we're breaking up. So Corky says, so now, in those days you did movies, you know they put the bands in movies. People wouldn't care about the movie, they'd want to go see the band, right? So we still do music from this, the worst motion picture in the world, Saving — no, not "Saving Private Ryan" no, "Private Buckaroo." Awful movie. It has the Andrews Sisters, has one of the — has Joe E. Lewis the comedian, and Harry James. And Harry James is a bugler that doesn't play, and has to be the bugler from — it's stupid, dumb. Donald O'Connor's first movie. And Corky is 16 now. So he's got a role in the movie. So Corky says, "We're out playing catch out in the sound lot of the movie theater, and this guy comes up to Donald O'Connor and he says, "How old are you?" Donald O'Connor says, "I'm 16 years old" or 17. He says, "Yeah? Where do you live?" And he says, "I live in Los Angeles." "Where's your parents?" "My mother is sitting over there." "Oh. And who are you?" And Corky says, "Who am I? What have you been living under a rock, I'm the famous saxophone player with Harry James." And he says, and he says, "And where do you live?" He says, "Tacoma, Washington." "How old are you?" And he says, "I'm 16" or 17. And he says, "And where's your parents?" "Well if I live in Tacoma where do you think they are?" So this is a truant officer. So he goes over to Harry James and he goes, "You are in violation of the child labor law act of California. You have to send him back or he has to have a legal guardian." Now it gets better. He goes to Betty Grable, who is also on the set, "Okay Mrs. Corcoran, this is Harry James." "Well is Corky all right?" "Yes. We have a question to ask you. We would like to adopt Corky." "What? Okay." So Harry and Betty Grable adopted Corky Corcoran so he could stay in the band, and he stayed on the band 38 years. So that's why he was always there. And on every recording I'd say, 90 percent of Harry James recordings there's always a Corky Corcoran solo. Maybe it could be four bars, eight bars, feature, always. Corky could do no wrong.

MR: This is not a question but an observation. I watched a video of the band with you and took note of the song that had a singer and how the band played the tune and then it modulated for the singer. Not a question, I think it's just an interesting thing, because I know it was fairly common for the arrangers to do that. And it was musically a good decision, sometimes a practical decision. The band sounds better in this key, the singer sings better in this key.

FR: Yeah. Well the thing that Harry did that no other band did — see all the band leaders like Benny Goodman, Artie — they hated singers. I mean as crude as this sounds, this is how they used to think. Get a canary that looks good, put her in front of the piano so it dresses up the band. Have her come up and sing a few things. That's how they thought, right? Okay. So if you stop and think about it, Benny Goodman introduction, Benny Goodman made the first statement, the singer would sing in the middle, and Benny Goodman would

make the final statement at the end. All bands were that way except Harry. Harry thought why doesn't the band play an introduction and the singer makes the first statement, I play the middle part, and the singer makes the final statement. He was the first one to do that. That's like when he got Frank Sinatra. And you know that story, how he found him and wanted to change his name and all that. I tell that on the show you know, briefly. And so, and of course Harry James was the first one to do that. And of course his long association with Helen Forrest, everybody says, and I knew Connie Haynes who was his first singer, very well, and I knew Helen and did some TV and recordings with her. Everybody says she was the best. The best big band singer ever. And Sinatra said that too. And it was really cute, when we got ready to do the Fiftieth Anniversary show, and I did a TV show with her in Seattle and — did you know the Schribman Brothers?

MR: Yes.

FR: Well they owned the band business. I think they were the predecessors to Willard Alexander I think, you know from Boston. Joe Schribman was the manager of The Lancers, that's where I knew him, and he was the last one. And he absolutely loved me. Joe Schribman used to call me up and he'd say, he was serious, he'd go, "Fred." I said, "Joe" in those days you paid for long distance calls, I said, "Joe why don't you call first and then call me. Your call would be cheaper." So there was supposed to be a TV show for PBS in Seattle with Helen Forrest and the Modernnaires and everything. And they were going to use the University of Washington jazz band. And the leader of that band was kind of a jerk. And the music didn't come in time. So she says, "We're not going to do it. You'll have to find somebody else." So Joe Schribman had booked it with Joe Graydon, who had things with Columbia Artists, and he says, "Well Jeez, get a hold of Fred Radke, I mean I know Fred." So at the last minute, three days, got my guys and we did this TV show and Helen Forrest was on it and Joe Graydon came up, because he was the producer of the show, and he says, "You know something? I guess — you're going to hear from me in a couple of days. We're doing a Fiftieth Anniversary of Harry James and you're perfect." And he says, "I know you were with Harry, Joe Schribman thinks a lot of you." And so a couple of days later he had gone to the estate and they had two different trumpet players that ran the band. And so the last one, I can't remember who it was, but they said, "Well you're going out for like four months, the Fiftieth Anniversary national tour. And "No" he said, "we don't want that kind of — " And they said, "Well there's only one person we allow to even think about leading that band," and he says, "that's Fred Radke." He says, "That's who we want." So that's how I got the band. But so when Joe Schribman used to come to Vegas, he came a couple of times, he'd walk in and Harry'd say, "Hey Joe how are you?" He said, "I'm not here to see you, I'm here to see

Fred." I don't know, it seems like — not attract but it just seems like obtain a lot of people or something. I don't know.

MR: You have an extra dose of charm I think.

FR: No I hate to say this but I really know a lot of people. And it's funny to me. And I really know them. I mean somebody, if you ask me, say hey do you know so-and-so who owns so-and-so do you think you can give me a — yeah sure hey. I have somebody I want you to see right now. Yeah. In fact I'm doing that tomorrow with a couple of students. Somebody's coming in from Washington, DC and they said, jeez we're trying to get a position there. I said, "Well do you know" so-and-so. "Oh yeah but." Well he's coming to see me Saturday, I'll put you at his table. What's it to me? You know.

MR: This has been a fascinating conversation and I'd like to wrap up with the fact that you have this terrific relationship with Hillsdale College. It's wonderful to hear that you're working with the trumpet students. Do you have any words of wisdom that you share with them about trying to — if they express this interest of —

FR: Continuing in music?

MR: Continuing in music.

FR: That's a — you know the music business is a tough thing today as you know. And I think, what I tell anybody, it's all passion. And I think if you're passionate about what you want to do, and you want to be a trumpet player then follow that passion. And you know if you visualize, if you want to look at — look what I visualized. And I have a great wife, she's just great, and I have great children and grandchildren and great grandchildren, and Cocoa Puff, our dog. You know just, and great friends. You know if you're a positive person and leave your ego at the stage door canteen. I love once again referring back to Bobby Shew. He says forget your ego man. As you get older what's — ego is, that's for children. And I think for students if they want to pursue that go for it. Have your passion. You have to have the passion. You have to have the drive. You have to want it bad enough. And then you go for it. And that's what I'd say. This place, Hillsdale College, I've been coming here for five or six years. I don't know if you've had time just to sit around and observe. The other day I was sitting on the bench up there and then I went to the dining room and just sitting there watching students. This is a positive, happy place. Everybody smiles, everybody is extremely polite, everybody is friendly, and it's just a positive place to be. And I was watching, you know, just people walking down the street, laughing, talking, arms around each other, shaking hands. In the cafeteria sit down with a couple of other professors and they engaged in doing, you know very important conversations. It's just a positive place. And I think that a student that goes here who is very privileged to do so, to have the opportunity to come and get this

education at this institution, they're going to leave here with a positive driving force and driving attitude to do what they want to do. I really feel that.

MR: I sense that as well. And I was at the dining hall myself and there was a table behind me of fellas, they could have been on the football team if they have one.

FR: Oh yeah they do.

MR: All of a sudden they broke into a piece from an opera. They were singing opera. Not well but with such joy and verve that I said what a nice thing to hear in the dining hall.

FR: Yeah sure, no I'm telling you. You know I was involved with the University of Washington for you know some years, and then compared to this? Well you're involved with a university you know. It's just a positive — everybody's here because they want to be here. It's not because Mommy and Daddy is sending them to school to learn how to drink beer. You know they're here because they want to learn and they want to learn positive life values. And that comes from the leadership too, because the leadership of this school is something else. And Dr. Arnn — Larry — is just an incredible — I don't know if you've met him but he's a pretty incredible man. He's a very positive person. And that's what he portrays in this place. And just good people. Enjoyable to be here. And Chris is great too, our jazz guy.

MR: Yes indeed. Well thank you for your time, Fred, and you know what? I think you should become a professional musician. Best of luck with your future endeavors,

FR: Good thank you.

MR: And I look forward to hearing you play the trumpet.

FR: It's so great to be with you. Thank you.

MR: And we're out.

[1:20:31]